

Renaissance of the Poor Soul

A journey through the many faces of the human spirit

HALALISANI NGEMA



Cover

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SOUL

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DEDICATION

In honour of Busisiwe H Mkhize, my Mother.

My first teacher in the subject of endurance.

You taught me what it is like to carry a load heavier than any soul can bear and still stand.

This book stands.

For every soul that has wandered, wept, and waited.

Your time is coming.

| *"Fika Nkosi la ngingafikanga khona mina."*

| *Lord, reach beyond the limits of my prayer.*

| — Mr E Mkhize (Mkhulu Mkhize, in prayer)

FOREWORD

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Before we had language for it, we felt it. Before theology named it and philosophers debated it and scientists dismissed it, something inside every human being has always known that there is more to a person than flesh and bone. That knowing has a name. We call it the soul.

Throughout human history, across every culture and tradition, one question has refused to leave us. Not the question of how the stars were formed. Not whether God exists. Those are profound questions, but they are questions about things outside of us. The question that follows us into our darkest nights, that surfaces at our most honest moments and whispers beneath every loss we have ever suffered, is more intimate than any of those. It is the question we ask not about the universe but about ourselves.

What is the soul? And what happens to it?

It is the question asked by the Egyptian priest preparing a body for burial, and by the mother sitting beside a grave that should never have been dug. It is the question of the philosopher in his study and the prisoner in his cell. It is the question behind every religion ever founded, every temple ever built, every prayer ever whispered in the dark by someone who was not sure anyone was listening but could not stop themselves from speaking anyway.

No generation has answered it finally. No tradition has silenced it completely. And perhaps that is the point. Perhaps the question of the soul is not meant to be closed. It is meant to be lived, carried, wrestled with, and allowed to deepen us in the carrying.

This book does not claim to have the final answer. It is an invitation. A gentle walk through the spiritual landscape of what our ancestors called the soul, and the many conditions in which a soul might find itself over the course of a lifetime, or even across multiple lifetimes.

It was not written from a pulpit or from a place of arrival. It was written from the wilderness. From the long nights, the unanswered prayers, the rejected applications, the seasons where God seemed silent and life seemed impossible. If it carries any authority at all, it is the authority of someone who has lived what is written here and who still, somehow, stubbornly, chooses to believe.

My grandfather used to close every prayer with the words: Fika Nkosi la ngingafikanga khona mina. Lord, reach beyond the limits of my prayer. That prayer is woven into every page of this book. May it reach where I could not.

— Halalisani Ngema

Johannesburg, 2026

INTRODUCTION

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If you have ever prayed with everything you had and heard nothing back, at least not in the way you expected, this book was written for you.

It was written for the person who has done everything right and still found themselves in the wrong place. For the person who has been faithful, tried hard, loved genuinely, and still ended up on the losing side of too many situations to count. For the person sitting in a season so dark and so long that they have begun to wonder whether light is even real.

Nothing is wrong with you. You are just not where you were meant to grow. Yet.

This book will not tell you that if you pray harder, give more, or believe better, everything will be fixed. That is not the book you are holding. What this book will tell you, and show you chapter by chapter, is that your soul is not broken. It is not cursed. It is not abandoned. It is in a process that has a name, a shape, and a destination.

The word Renaissance in the title is intentional. Renaissance means rebirth. A coming back to life after a period of darkness or dormancy. The Renaissance in history was preceded by centuries of struggle. And then, out of that long difficult night, came an explosion of art, thought, beauty, and human flourishing that changed the world forever. That is the promise held out to the poor soul. Not that the darkness will be avoided. But that it will not have the last word.

This book follows a journey. It begins with displacement, the sense of being in the wrong place, at the wrong time, overlooked by everyone except God. It moves through confrontation, the raw, honest reckoning with what life has been. It passes through cracking open, the painful moment when the soul stops pretending. It arrives at reframing, the slow discovery that the road has always been taking you somewhere. And it ends in rest. Not the rest of giving up, but the rest of a soul that has finally found its footing.

Each chapter stands alone. You can read this book from cover to cover or open it to wherever your soul lands. Either way, something here was written for you.

Read this book as you would receive a conversation from someone who has been where you are and lived to tell about it. Not a

preacher. Not a professor. A fellow traveller. Bruised, still walking, still believing.

Your renaissance is not behind you. It is ahead.

This is not a book of answers. It is a book of honest company.

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PART ONE

DISPLACEMENT

The feeling of being in the wrong place. The wrong job. The wrong season. The sense that life has misplaced you, or worse, that you have misplaced yourself.

You have not been forgotten. You have been relocated.

WHAT IS THE SOUL?

Before we can talk about what happens to the soul, we need to understand what it is. And that is harder than it sounds.

The soul is not the body. It is not the mind, though it interacts with both. Across almost every tradition that has ever tried to define it, the soul emerges as the invisible, enduring core of a person. The seat of consciousness, moral awareness, identity, and spiritual capacity. The part of you that persists when everything else changes.

What the World's Traditions Say

In Christianity, the soul is the immortal, God-breathed essence of every human being. It carries within it the image of the divine, what theologians call the *imago Dei*. This is what makes a human being not merely an animal, but a being capable of love, conscience, worship, and moral choice.

In Islam, the *ruh* is breathed into each person by God and returned to Him at death. The soul is a sacred gift and a responsibility. To honour the soul is to honour God.

In Hinduism, the *atman* is the individual expression of Brahman, the universal, ultimate reality. The soul is not created; it is eternal and divine by nature. Its journey across multiple lifetimes is called *samsara*, and liberation, *moksha*, is its ultimate destination.

In Buddhism, the concept is more nuanced. There is no permanent, unchanging soul. Instead, a continuum of consciousness, a stream of mental and karmic energy flowing from one life to the next. The goal is nirvana: the end of craving, suffering, and the karmic cycle.

In African traditional spirituality, the soul is understood in terms of community and ancestry. A person's spirit is not simply individual. It is connected to the living, the dead, and those yet to be born. The soul carries the wisdom of the ancestors and has responsibilities to the community.

The soul is not what you are inside. It is the inside of what you are.

A Personal Awakening

For some of us, the soul awakens in the most unexpected places. I was a child, sitting in a rondavel without a roof in Mandeni, KwaZulu-Natal, my hometown, when I posed a question to a cousin of mine. I asked if we were not going to be attacked by bad people, since the rondavel we were sitting in had no roof and it would be easy for someone to come in and hurt us. My cousin answered and said that we were safe because God was protecting us. Those words landed in a way that had nothing to do with theology and everything to do with truth. Something in that child recognised what was being

said. As though a door had been knocked on that had always been there, waiting.

That was the first time my soul understood it had an antenna. And that antenna was already pointed somewhere before I had words for it.

Not long after, another cousin introduced a very different face of the same God. One who punishes children who do wrong. And so, very early in life, two pictures of God sat side by side in one young soul: the Protector and the Punisher. That tension, who is this God, really, is a question that drives many souls into their most honest searching.

In my grandfather's house, an Ethiopian Catholic Church reverend would hold Sunday sermons in the living room. I did not always grasp what was being said. But when my grandfather prayed, when he spoke to God with that particular tone in his voice, something in my own spirit moved. I know now it was the soul recognising itself in another soul's devotion.

And then there were the Amadlozi ceremonies. My grandfather's voice when he called on the ancestors before a ceremony carried the same sacred weight as his Christian prayers. The same tone. The same reaching. It took many years to understand that he was not

doing two different things. He was doing one thing: reaching toward the divine by every name he knew.

His closing prayer said it all: Fika Nkosi la ngingafikanga khona mina. Lord, reach beyond the limits of my prayer. He knew that the divine is always larger than our language for it.

"You don't have a soul. You are a soul. You have a body. - C.S. Lewis"

The Earth Soul and the Divine Soul

One of the most illuminating frameworks comes from the psychoanalytic-spiritual work of Clifford S. Waldman, who draws on both biblical wisdom and modern psychological insight to describe the soul as having a dual nature. The Earth Soul and the Divine Soul.

The Earth Soul is the aspect of us shaped by experience. By trauma, by wounds, by the hardships of living in a broken world. It is the soul in the middle of suffering: reactive, self-protective, sometimes closed off. When life has been hard enough for long enough, the Earth Soul bears the marks of it. It is not evil. It is wounded. And wounded things protect themselves.

The Divine Soul, by contrast, is the pure, untainted connection to God's original blueprint for who we are. The part of us capable of love, creativity, compassion, and spiritual insight. It cannot be destroyed. It can be buried, silenced, suppressed. But it cannot be eliminated. It is always there, underneath the pain, waiting.

The journey of the soul is not the elimination of the Earth Soul. It is its redemption.

THE POOR SOUL

Of all the soul types that spiritual traditions have described over the centuries, the poor soul may be the most tenderly regarded. The word poor here does not refer to material poverty. It speaks to something far deeper.

A poor soul is one that is spiritually lacking, dependent, and in need of the prayers and compassion of others. In many traditions, this is not a condition of shame. It is a condition of profound humility and need.

The poor soul is not weak. It is honest about its emptiness. That honesty is the beginning.

What Spiritual Traditions Say

Across the world's spiritual traditions, the poor soul shares a consistent profile. A lack of inner richness, the absence of virtues like compassion, wisdom, or peace. A weight of suffering, being weighed down by fear, guilt, or addiction. A separation from the sacred, a felt distance from God or a higher purpose. And a readiness for transformation.

In many Christian contexts, the poor soul invokes Jesus's mercy toward the spiritually needy, emphasising repentance, grace, and redemption. The poor soul is not condemned. It is the very target of divine compassion.

In Buddhist and Hindu thought, the poor soul points to avidya, ignorance, and to dukkha, the cycle of suffering. The soul is not evil; it is unaware. And awareness is the beginning of liberation.

In Sufi thought, the poor soul describes a seeker who longs for the divine with a humble, yearning heart. The poverty of the soul is not its shame. It is its qualification. It is the very emptiness that makes it capable of being filled by the Beloved.

What unites all these traditions is this: the poor soul is not a lost cause. It is a soul in transition. Between emptiness and fullness.

Between separation and return. The poverty is not permanent. It is the condition that precedes the renaissance.

Blessed Are the Poor in Spirit

Perhaps the most striking teaching about the poor soul comes from Jesus in the Sermon on the Mount. His very first beatitude is: Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

This is a radical reversal of ordinary human values. In the world's reckoning, those who are strong, self-sufficient, and confident in their own righteousness are the ones to be admired. Jesus says the opposite. Those who know their own emptiness, their own need, their own utter dependence on God. These are the ones closest to the Kingdom.

Poverty of spirit is not weakness. It is honesty. It is the willingness to hold your hands open rather than clenched, to receive rather than insist on self-sufficiency.

The poor soul teaches us something essential about the nature of grace: it cannot be earned or manufactured. It can only be received. And receiving requires a certain kind of emptiness. The holy poverty that makes room for something greater than ourselves.

*"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith.
And this is not from yourselves; it is the gift of God.
Not by works, so that no one can boast. - Ephesians
2:8-9"*

THE AFFLICTED SOUL

If the poor soul is one who is empty, the afflicted soul is one who is in pain. Affliction comes from the Latin *afflictio*, meaning to strike down. It describes a condition of being burdened, pressed upon, and suffering under a weight that seems impossible to bear.

The afflicted soul carries wounds. These wounds may be physical, emotional, spiritual, or some inseparable combination of all three. What distinguishes the afflicted soul from someone simply having a hard time is the depth and persistence of the suffering. And often, the sense that the suffering is undeserved or disproportionate to any fault of their own.

Sources of Soul Affliction

Affliction can enter a soul through many doors. Prolonged injustice, when a person has been wronged, oppressed, or mistreated with no

recourse, creates a deep wound. The soul was made for dignity and fairness. When these are consistently denied, something inside begins to ache in a way that no distraction can touch.

Grief is another great source of affliction. The loss of someone deeply loved can afflict the soul in ways that have no easy words. Grief is the price of love. The depth of the grief is the measure of the love. The affliction that follows is simply love with nowhere to go.

Betrayal creates a particular form of soul affliction. When someone we trusted violates that trust, the wound reaches into the soul's fundamental beliefs about the world. Is it safe to trust? Is love real? Is goodness real? These are soul-level questions, and their disruption creates soul-level pain.

Generational wounds, traumas passed down through families and communities, can also afflict a soul before it has any personal experience of the original wound. The soul carries the memory of its lineage.

Affliction does not mean God has abandoned you. Sometimes it means God is deepening you.

When the Mind Itself Becomes the Battlefield

One of the most profound and least discussed dimensions of soul affliction is the connection between mental illness and the suffering of the spirit. Today we understand mental illness far more clearly as a condition of the brain and mind. But this understanding does not separate it from the soul's experience. If anything, it deepens it.

Depression, anxiety, bipolar disorder, schizophrenia, post-traumatic stress, obsessive-compulsive disorder. These are not simply medical categories. They are also spiritual experiences. The person living with severe depression does not merely feel sad. They experience a darkness that can make God feel absent, hope feel impossible, and the soul's inner light feel entirely extinguished.

The person battling anxiety does not merely worry too much. They live in a state of constant interior alarm. A soul that cannot find rest, cannot trust the ground beneath its feet, cannot receive peace even when peace is being offered. The restlessness is not chosen. The torment is not performed. It is real, and it is exhausting.

"My soul is overwhelmed with sorrow to the point of death. - Matthew 26:38"

These are the words of Jesus in the Garden of Gethsemane. And they are the words of every soul that has ever been brought to the edge of itself by a suffering that feels unbearable. The fact that Jesus

himself used this language should forever silence any voice that tells the mentally suffering soul that their pain is weakness, or sin, or lack of faith.

If you are reading this while living with a mental health condition, know this: your affliction does not disqualify you from the spiritual journey. It does not mean you are abandoned, punished, or forgotten. It means you are carrying something heavy. And the divine has never once looked away from those who carry heavy things.

"The Lord is close to the brokenhearted and saves those who are crushed in spirit. - Psalm 34:18"

"Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. - Matthew 11:28"

PART TWO

CONFRONTATION

The moment you stop pretending everything is fine. The moment you look at your life honestly and say: this is not where I wanted to be. This is the part most people skip. It is also the part that changes everything.

Honest suffering is the beginning of honest healing.

THE POOR AND AFFLICTED SOUL

Can a soul be both poor and afflicted at once? Not only is it possible. It is, in many ways, the most common human condition. The person who is spiritually empty is often also the person who is suffering. These two conditions feed each other, deepen each other, and compound each other in ways that can feel overwhelming.

You are not doubly cursed. You are doubly forming.

When Poverty and Affliction Meet

Consider the person who grew up without love. They begin life with a kind of soul poverty; they are not filled with the sense of being cherished, wanted, or of infinite worth. Then, as life unfolds, they experience further blows. Failed relationships, loss, rejection,

illness. Each new wound lands on soil that was already depleted. There is no deep reservoir of stored peace or trust to draw on. Each affliction cuts closer to the bone.

Or consider the person who was once spiritually rich. Full of faith, hope, a sense of God's presence and care. Then something devastating happens: the death of a child, a profound injustice, a betrayal by the very community that was supposed to hold them. They find themselves suddenly both afflicted and impoverished. Stripped of the wound and the resources they would normally use to process it.

"It is in the darkest dungeons that the light of grace burns most unexpectedly bright. - Thomas Merton"

To be a poor and afflicted soul is to carry a double burden. One is the burden of the wound itself. The grief, the pain, the injustice. The other is the burden of facing that wound without the inner spiritual resources that might otherwise help you bear it. It is like being asked to carry a heavy load with injured hands.

And yet, the spiritual traditions speak with remarkable unanimity on this: this is not a condition of hopelessness. When a soul has been emptied of everything it thought it possessed, it becomes capable of receiving a grace it could never have accepted before.

I know what it is to be both at once. In 2010, I found myself in a place of deep questioning. I was doing what was right. Not chasing trouble, focusing on my work at the bank, trying to be the man my children needed. And yet things were falling apart. Family members were dying. The workplace that was supposed to be stable became a place of mistreatment so severe that I eventually resigned. Not because I was weak, but because a soul can only absorb so much before something inside it breaks.

Then I moved to another branch. The trouble followed. Then another. Then a transfer to Mandeni, where I was pinned down by a branch manager and a team leader who seemed determined to make me small. I left again.

In 2016, my mother passed.

Years later, in Johannesburg, I found myself on a night shift, sitting on a final written warning, being sent back to training, while colleagues who started alongside me had already tried to block me from being signed as a full employee before I had even begun. On the 24th of March 2026, that job came to an end as well.

And through all of it I kept asking God: Is this what you want for me? A father of three who cannot do anything for his children? That question, asked in frustration, in grief, in the raw honesty of a soul

that has stopped performing, is not a crisis of faith. It is faith. It is the kind of prayer that God does not flinch from, because it is real.

There are seasons in a life that do not arrive one at a time. They pile on. They compound. And just when you think you have found solid ground, the ground moves again.

Another profound chapter of this journey is that I spent five years trying my hand in business. Five years of hoping, building, adjusting, and believing that the next thing would be the thing that turned it around. Things fell apart. I became a slave to alcohol. A relationship I had stayed in for a long time, trying to build a happy family for my children, fell to pieces. The dream of giving my children a stable home, the one thing I had fought hardest for, slipped through my hands in that season.

Finally, when I found a job in Johannesburg, I was let go. This happened just two days after burying my father.

Two days.

There are moments in life that defy explanation. Moments where the weight of everything arrives at once, and you are left standing in the middle of it wondering what kind of story you are living in. I was a man who had just put his father in the ground, still carrying

the soil of that burial on his hands, and the phone rang with news that the job was gone. I did not have a theology for that moment. I did not have a scripture ready. I had only the raw, unfiltered reality of a soul that had been hit from every direction and was still, somehow, standing.

There is a particular grief that comes from discovering a gift, developing it with everything you have, and then being told by the world that it does not want it.

I had aspired to be a musician. The keyboard and piano were not just instruments to me. They were a language, a way of expressing what words could not always carry. I started where many do, playing in one key, relying on the transpose function to get by. But I knew that was not enough. So I made a decision that only someone who truly loves something would make: I taught myself every key on the piano. Not because someone asked me to. Not because there was a reward waiting. But because I wanted to play fully, not partially. I wanted to offer everything, not a shortcut.

And when I could finally play in all keys, when I had done the hard, quiet, lonely work of mastering what most people avoid, I was met with what I can only describe as the most brutal of rejections. No one wanted me anywhere near them. Not the churches. Not the bands. Not the events. The very thing I had poured myself into and

refused to do halfway was turned away at every door. It all came down on me like a ton of bricks.

During those five years of unemployment, I turned to another dream. I started a business as a blogger, ran a couple of websites, put my thoughts and my voice into the world through writing. That too failed.

There is something uniquely tormenting about repeated failure across different dreams. It is not just disappointment. It begins to feel like a verdict. Like the universe itself has looked at you and decided: not this one. Not him. And the soul, already poor and afflicted, begins to wonder whether the problem is the dream, or whether the problem is the dreamer.

It is neither. The problem is the timing. And timing belongs to God.

The Gathering at Adullam

There is a moment in David's story that is rarely preached about, but it may be the most honest passage in all of Scripture about what it means to be a poor and afflicted soul.

After David fled from Saul, after the anointing and before the throne, he found himself hiding in a cave at Adullam. And who came to him there? Not the powerful. Not the celebrated. Not the

ones who had their lives together. Scripture tells us that everyone who was in distress came to him. Everyone who was in debt. Everyone who was discontented. The broken, the burdened, the overlooked, the ones society had no place for. They found their way to the cave where David was hiding, and they made him their leader.

"And everyone who was in distress, and everyone who was in debt, and everyone who was discontented gathered to him. And he became captain over them. And there were with him about four hundred men. - 1 Samuel 22:2"

Four hundred poor and afflicted souls gathered around a man who was himself a poor and afflicted soul. And out of that cave, out of that gathering of broken people, came the army that would eventually take David to his throne.

This is the word for every soul that feels too broken to be used, too burdened to be chosen, too overlooked to matter. David did not build his legacy with the comfortable. He built it with the desperate. And the desperate built something that history could not ignore.

You are not too broken to be gathered. Sometimes the cave is where the army forms.

Rejection, Endurance, and the Deepening of the Soul

There is a particular crucible that many poor and afflicted souls find themselves in. The experience of being rejected at the door, again and again. Rejected for jobs, rejected in relationships, overlooked for opportunities. And in the aftermath of each rejection, finding yourself in a situation that causes pain. And staying there not because you have no dreams, but because the alternative door has not yet opened.

To stay at a job where you are suffering, not because you are lazy or afraid, but because the world outside has closed its doors to you. This is not failure. It is endurance. And endurance, done with awareness, is one of the most powerful spiritual practices available to the human soul.

"We also glory in our sufferings, because we know that suffering produces perseverance; perseverance, character; and character, hope. - Romans 5:3-4"

Paul's progression is precise and deeply true. Suffering produces perseverance. Perseverance produces character. And character, fully formed, produces hope. Not naive optimism, but a hope that has been hammered into shape by reality and has survived.

The Wound of Unrecognised Gifts

There is a particular affliction that strikes the poor and afflicted soul with a cruelty that is almost surgical in its precision. It is the experience of being capable, genuinely, measurably capable, and yet not being trusted.

You can drive, and you have driven safely for years, yet those around you treat every journey as though disaster is imminent. You can speak; you have words, ideas, a message that matters, yet when you rise to deliver it, you see doubt in the eyes of those around you that has nothing to do with your actual ability. You can handle money, manage a project, lead a team, play an instrument, and yet the people in your life hover and second-guess and micromanage as if you were a child.

This is gaslighting of the soul. It is the slow erosion of self-knowledge by the persistent pressure of other people's unbelief. And it is a genuine spiritual wound. Every human being is made with gifts. To have those gifts consistently dismissed, doubted, and overlooked is to experience a kind of spiritual injustice.

"A prophet is not accepted in his hometown. - Luke 4:24"

Jesus himself named this experience. The people who knew him best could not receive what he carried. Their familiarity bred not appreciation but contempt. If the people around you cannot see your gifts, it does not mean the gifts are not there. Their blindness is not evidence of your incapacity. It is evidence of their own limitations.

You are not too much. You are not too little. You are in the wrong room.

THE LOST SOUL

The image of a lost soul calls to mind a traveller who has lost the path, a ship without navigation, a child who has wandered from home and cannot find the way back. The lost soul is not necessarily in pain, at least not in the acute way of the afflicted soul. But there is a hollowness, a disorientation, a sense that something essential has been misplaced or forgotten.

A lost soul is someone who has become disconnected from their own deepest nature. From their sense of purpose, meaning, identity, and belonging. They may be going through the motions of daily life

while feeling, inside, that they are not really there. Present in body but absent in spirit.

How Souls Become Lost

Some are lost gradually, through years of choices that moved them incrementally away from what they knew to be true and good. Each small compromise, each silenced inner voice. These accumulate over time until the soul looks up and realises it has no idea where it is.

Others are lost in a single catastrophic moment. A trauma that shattered their sense of reality. An experience of profound disillusionment that stripped away the beliefs and structures that had previously given their lives meaning.

Still others are born into conditions of lostness. Environments so chaotic, violent, or neglectful that the normal processes of soul formation were interrupted from the very beginning.

┆ *"Not all those who wander are lost. - J.R.R. Tolkien"*

There is a difference between wandering and being lost. The wanderer is exploring, moving without a fixed destination but with an inner sense of aliveness and curiosity. The lost soul, by contrast,

is moving without direction and without the inner resources to find direction again. The wandering soul may find its way. The lost soul needs, above all, to be found.

The Good Shepherd

The most famous image of the lost soul in Christian tradition is the parable of the lost sheep. A shepherd has one hundred sheep. One goes missing. He leaves the ninety-nine and searches diligently, tirelessly, and lovingly until the lost one is found. And when it is found, the celebration is greater than the joy over the ninety-nine who never strayed.

The lost soul is not abandoned. It is sought. The initiative is not with the lost soul to find its own way back. It is with the divine to seek, to search, to never stop looking. The lost soul needs only to become still enough, quiet enough, to hear the sound of the One who is searching for it.

THE RESTLESS SOUL

The restless soul has a very keen sense that there is somewhere it needs to be. It just cannot quite find it. There is an inner agitation, a

perpetual sense that something is not yet right, not yet complete.

"Our heart is restless until it reposes in Thee. - St Augustine of Hippo"

Augustine himself was a restless soul. Brilliant, passionate, driven by desire, moving from one philosophy to another, always finding them ultimately unsatisfying, always reaching for something more. His insight was that the restlessness of the soul is not a malfunction. It is, in fact, a homing signal. The soul is restless because it was made for a rest it has not yet found.

Restlessness is not a problem. It is a compass. Pay attention to where it points.

Restlessness as Spiritual Compass

The soul that is too easily satisfied, that finds its rest in comfort, security, routine, and the approval of others, may never search deeply enough to find the truth it was made for. Restlessness keeps the soul honest. It refuses to let us settle for less than we were made for.

This does not mean that all restlessness is holy. Some restlessness is simply anxiety or avoidance dressed in spiritual language. But at its

truest, the restless soul is one that has not yet been able to say yes to life fully, because something in it knows that the fullest yes is still ahead.

THE TORMENTED SOUL

The tormented soul experiences something closer to an active inner war. A fierce, unrelenting conflict between different parts of itself, or between itself and forces it experiences as outside and overwhelming. Torment differs from ordinary suffering in its intensity and its relentlessness. The anguish is constant, cutting, and often feels as though it has no end.

The Nature of Inner Torment

Inner torment often has its roots in profound guilt. The sense that one has done something irreparably wrong, that the damage one has caused cannot be undone and therefore cannot be forgiven. This is different from healthy remorse, which leads to repair and growth. Torment circles endlessly, without resolution. It punishes without redeeming.

Shame, which is distinct from guilt, can also be a source of torment. Where guilt says I did something bad, shame says I am bad. The tormented soul haunted by shame does not believe it has failed at something. It believes it is a failure as a being.

"The spirit is willing, but the flesh is weak. - Matthew 26:41"

For the tormented soul, the great need is not instruction. It already knows what is right. The great need is liberation. Freedom from the forces that keep it in bondage to patterns of thought, behaviour, or belief that cause it to suffer.

I know this territory personally. There was a season in my life when I joined a church community not out of love, not out of genuine encounter with God, but out of fear. Fear of hell. Fear of being left behind during the Rapture. Fear of suffering without end. I was a good person, not chasing sin, trying to do right, and yet I was tormented by the possibility that it was never enough.

That is a particular kind of torment: to try hard, to genuinely want to be good, and still to feel that the ground beneath your feet is never truly safe. The soul was not made to relate to God through terror. It was made to relate through love. And when the foundation is fear

rather than love, the soul twists itself into knots that prayer alone cannot untie.

God is not a threat. God is a refuge. The tormented soul deserves to know the difference.

PART THREE

CRACKING OPEN

The moment the soul stops holding everything together by force. The moment something gives way. This is not collapse. This is the beginning of space. Space for something new to enter.

You do not have to hold it all together. Some things are meant to crack open.

THE WEARY SOUL

There is a particular kind of exhaustion that goes beyond the physical. A tiredness that sleep cannot cure, a fatigue that pervades not just the body but the very depths of the person. This is the condition of the weary soul.

The weary soul has often been a warrior. It has fought for justice, for survival, for those it loves, for its own integrity, for its faith. It has carried heavy loads for a long time. It has got up after being knocked down, again and again. And it has done this so many times that the effort itself has become exhausting.

*"Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened,
and I will give you rest. - Matthew 11:28"*

The invitation in these words is not to try harder, nor to be ashamed of the weariness. It is simply: come. Bring the exhaustion to a place of rest. The weary soul's greatest need is permission. Permission to stop, to put down the load, to receive rather than give, to be still.

Rest is not giving up. Rest is an act of faith.

Weariness, like all the other conditions of the soul we have explored, is not a final destination. It is a season. And seasons change. The weary soul that allows itself to be replenished often

discovers, on the other side of rest, a renewed capacity and a deeper wisdom than it possessed before the weariness set in.

THE ANCIENT SOUL

The ancient soul, sometimes called the old soul, carries a wisdom, a depth, and a sense of familiarity with the world that their years do not explain. The child who asks profound questions before they have the language to articulate them. The teenager who feels more at home with the elderly than with their peers. The adult who looks at the world with a gentle, knowing sadness, as if they have seen this before, many times.

In traditions that teach reincarnation, the ancient soul is understood quite literally, as a soul that has lived many lives and carried the accumulated wisdom of those experiences into the present one. In other traditions, the ancient soul is understood more metaphorically, as one who has developed an unusual depth of inner maturity.

"We do not grow absolutely, chronologically. We grow sometimes in one dimension and not in another; unevenly. - Anais Nin"

Ancient souls often feel out of place in the modern world. Not because they are better than others, but because they are calibrated to a different frequency. They value depth over surface, substance over style, truth over comfort. Their presence, their quiet depth, their unhurried wisdom, their willingness to sit with what is real, is a gift that the world needs more, not less.

If you have always felt too deep for the rooms you were placed in, that is not a defect. That is a calling.

The Old Soul Archetype

Old Souls are characterised by an intrinsic sense of wisdom and depth that transcends their chronological age. They are drawn to philosophical and spiritual pursuits from an early age, often feeling more at home in quiet reflection or meaningful conversation than in the surface-level noise of contemporary life.

Old Souls often carry a kind of pre-existing sadness. Not depression, but a poignant awareness of the weight of existence. They have, in some sense, already seen enough to know that life is both beautiful and hard, and they hold both truths simultaneously in a way that younger souls have not yet learned to do. This is not pessimism. It is the deep realism of a soul that has been around long enough to know the full story.

If you are an ancient soul, your calling is not to hide your depth in order to fit in. It is to offer it. To the younger souls around you who are still finding their footing, to the communities and conversations that need the kind of grounded wisdom that only comes from having truly lived.

MODERN SOUL ARCHETYPES

Contemporary spirituality has developed a rich additional language for understanding the soul's identity and mission. These modern archetypes do not replace classical religious understanding. They complement it, offering individuals a framework for naming experiences and callings that traditional labels sometimes do not fully capture.

You may not have had the right word for what you are. That does not mean you are not something.

Earth Angels

Earth Angels are souls believed to be present on earth specifically to heal others through love and compassion. They carry an inherent empathy and nurturing quality that makes them natural comforters.

The challenge of the Earth Angel is boundaries. Because they feel so deeply and give so readily, they can become depleted. The spiritual work of the Earth Angel is learning that they cannot pour from an empty vessel, and that receiving care is not a betrayal of their calling. It is its prerequisite.

Starseeds

Starseeds are souls that carry a consciousness that feels not entirely of this world. They often describe a persistent sense of alienation from ordinary earthly concerns. A feeling of being on a mission that the surrounding culture cannot fully recognise or accommodate. Whether one takes this literally or metaphorically, the experience it describes is real and widely shared.

Lightworkers

Lightworkers are carriers of truth and transformational energy. Souls whose inner mission is to bring light into dark places, to inspire, to heal, to hold hope when others have lost it. The book you are holding was written by a Lightworker. Someone who, in the middle of their own long night, found a way to gather what they had learned and offer it to others still in the dark.

Warrior Souls

Warrior Souls are the protectors. Souls whose purpose is to confront injustice, break destructive cycles, and fight for balance and dignity in a world that too often denies these things to the vulnerable. The Warrior Soul's challenge is that the fight is long and the enemies are often invisible. Sustainable courage is not the absence of weariness but the refusal to let weariness become surrender.

Knowing Your Archetype

These archetypes are not rigid categories. They are mirrors. When you read one and feel something shift inside you, a recognition, a relief, a sense of finally being named, pay attention to that. The soul knows itself. It has always known itself. Sometimes it simply needs the right language to confirm what it has always carried.

And if you find yourself in the poor soul, the afflicted soul, the lost soul, do not assume these archetypes are for someone else. The Earth Angel in the dark is still an Earth Angel. The Warrior Soul sitting on a final written warning is still a Warrior Soul. The title describes the calling, not the current condition. The condition is temporary. The calling is not.

PART FOUR

REFRAMING

The slow, difficult, deeply necessary work of seeing your life differently. Not pretending it was not hard. Seeing that the hard was the point.

The road did not go wrong. It went deeper.

THE SEEKING SOUL

The seeking soul is driven by an active, conscious hunger for truth, for meaning, for the divine. The seeker knows what it is looking for, even if it cannot yet fully describe it. And it is willing to go a long way, and give a great deal, to find it.

Seeking souls are found in every tradition and in no tradition. They read everything, question everything, and travel far, literally or metaphorically, in search of the understanding that will make sense of their existence.

"Seek and you shall find; knock, and the door will be opened to you. - Matthew 7:7"

The seeking soul is promised, in many traditions, that the search itself is a form of faithfulness. The journey of seeking changes the seeker. It develops discernment, humility, openness, and a capacity for wonder. By the time the seeking soul finds what it has been looking for, it has been shaped by the search into someone ready to receive it.

One Soul, Many Doors

My own seeking led me through many doors. I grew up attending a Zion Spiritual Church called Four Square in the Isithebe area with my mother and siblings. Then my grandmother took us to the Shembe Nazareth Baptist Church. A place of white robes, sacred mountains, and a reverence that touched something ancestral and deep. Later we attended the Apostolic Faith Mission with our mother. Each tradition offered a different window into the same light.

Then at university, a friend invited me into yet another church. One that introduced me to teachings I had never encountered before. The mark of the Beast. The Rapture. The terrifying prospect of being left behind to suffer without end. These were not presented as

invitations to love. They were presented as reasons to fear. And so, for a season, I joined not because I was drawn by love but because I was driven by terror.

This is a journey that many seeking souls know. We search through traditions, communities, and teachers. Some of which nourish us and some of which wound us, all the time being shaped by the search itself. Looking back, I can see that even the season of fear-driven faith was teaching me something: that a soul cannot truly rest in a God it is only afraid of. Sooner or later, the seeking soul must find a God it can actually love.

The soul that has searched through many rooms knows the value of the one it finally rests in.

THE AWAKENED SOUL

The awakened soul has passed through a profound shift in consciousness and awareness. It is not simply that the awakened soul knows more than before; it sees differently. The world looks the same, but everything is understood in a new light.

Awakening in spiritual traditions is often described as a movement from sleep to wakefulness. The unawakened soul moves through life on autopilot, driven by habit, conditioning, fear, and desire, without ever pausing to examine the assumptions that govern its choices. The awakened soul has paused. It has looked beneath the surface of its own life and found something there, something real, something true, that it cannot unsee.

"The spiritual journey does not consist of arriving at a new destination but of having new eyes. - Marcel Proust"

Awakening is not the end of the journey. It is often the beginning of a deeper and more demanding one. The awakened soul must now integrate what it has seen into everyday life. It must learn to live from its new understanding in a world that often operates from the old one. This integration is its own profound challenge and discipline.

You are not the same person you were at the start of this road. That is not loss. That is the point.

THE REDEEMED SOUL

The redeemed soul has passed through suffering, lostness, poverty, affliction, torment, weariness, and come out the other side transformed. Not unscathed. Not unmarked. But transformed.

Redemption, at its root, means to buy back. To recover something that was lost, stolen, or surrendered. The redeemed soul is one that has been recovered. From the darkness it fell into, from the patterns that bound it, from the wounds that defined it.

What makes the redeemed soul remarkable is not that it has been restored to its original condition, as if the suffering never happened. The suffering happened. The wounds are real. But in the redeemed soul, these wounds have been transformed from sources of ongoing pain into sources of compassion, wisdom, and grace.

*"The wound is the place where the light enters you. -
Rumi"*

The wound, the very thing that broke the soul open, becomes the opening through which something luminous enters. The cracks in the soul are not defects. They are what allow the light to get in.

The redeemed soul does not pretend the past did not happen. It does not paste a smile over its scars. It carries its history with honesty. And with a kind of quiet authority that comes only from having truly suffered and having been truly found.

Your scars are not evidence of what broke you. They are evidence of what you survived.

NO SOUL BEYOND REACH

We have journeyed through many landscapes of the human soul. Poor and afflicted, lost and restless, tormented and weary, ancient and seeking, awakened and redeemed. Each condition is real. Each carries its own particular weight, its own particular wisdom.

But perhaps the most important thing to say, having travelled this far together, is this: no soul is beyond reach. Not the poorest soul, not the most afflicted, not the most deeply lost or the most profoundly tormented.

*"Even if I make my bed in the depths, you are there. -
Psalm 139:8"*

There is no place, no depth of lostness, no pit of despair, no darkness of soul, where the divine is not already present, waiting to be found.

The Journey Continues

The soul's journey is not a straight line from darkness to light. It is more like a spiral. Returning again and again to similar themes and challenges, but each time with slightly more awareness, slightly more capacity, slightly more grace.

The poor soul will know poverty again. But it will also know grace. The afflicted soul will suffer again. But it will also know healing. The lost soul will wander again. But it will also know the experience of being found.

What We Owe Each Other

We are not on this journey alone. The poor soul depends on the prayers of the living. The afflicted soul needs those who will sit with it in its pain. The lost soul needs those who will search for it. The weary soul needs those who will offer rest.

We are, each of us, at some point the one in need. And at other points, we are the one with something to offer. This is the great gift and responsibility of being souls together. Our journeys, however

private they feel, are always woven together in ways we may not fully see or understand.

The soul was never meant to make this journey alone. Neither were you.

PART FIVE

REST AND BECOMING

Not the rest of arriving. Not the rest of having finally fixed everything. The rest of a soul that has decided to stop fighting against itself, and start walking with itself instead.

You do not have to be finished to be at peace. You just have to keep walking.

SURVIVING THE LONG NIGHT

Everything we have explored in this book leads to a single practical question: How does a soul survive? How does a person in genuine spiritual, emotional, and circumstantial distress keep going?

This chapter is not a collection of quick fixes. Suffering is not a problem to be solved. It is a territory to be navigated. And what follows are the tools, the spiritual and practical wisdom, that have helped souls navigate it across centuries and across traditions.

You do not have to fear the suffering. It will not destroy what is most essentially you.

You Are Allowed to Feel It All

Do not perform wellness. Do not pretend to be further along than you are. Do not paste a spiritual veneer over genuine pain and call it faith. The Psalms are full of raw, unedited anguish, and they are considered among the holiest texts in existence. If Scripture makes room for My God, my God, why have you forsaken me, then so does your spiritual life.

Feel what you feel. Name it. Let it move through you. The soul that is allowed to grieve, to rage, to weep, to question, to doubt, that soul is processing. That soul is alive and in motion.

Anchor Yourself in Small Faithfulnesses

When the soul is under siege, grand gestures of faith are often not available. What matters in the long night is not the grand gesture. It is the small faithfulness, repeated.

Light a candle. Say one sentence of honest prayer. Step outside and breathe real air. Read one verse, one line, one word that is true. Drink water. Rest when you can. These are not lesser spiritual acts. They are survival acts. And the soul that performs small faithfulnesses in the dark is a soul that is keeping the flame alive.

It will not always feel like enough. It is always enough.

Find One Witness

The suffering soul was not designed to suffer alone. One of the most important things you can do in a season of deep affliction is find one person, just one, who can witness your experience without flinching, without fixing, without offering easy answers. Someone who will sit with you in the darkness and simply refuse to leave.

If you cannot find this person in your immediate life, look wider. A counsellor or therapist. A pastor or spiritual director. A trusted voice in a community of faith. Sometimes the witness is a book, the words of someone who has been where you are and lived to write about it.

Do Not Despise the Wilderness

Many of the greatest souls in history spent significant seasons in the wilderness. In the in-between places where they were no longer where they had been, but not yet where they were going. Moses spent forty years in the desert before he led anyone anywhere. David spent years running from Saul before he became king. Jesus spent forty days in the wilderness before his public ministry began.

The wilderness is not wasted time. It is formation time. It is the place where the soul is stripped of what it does not need, where pretence falls away, where the deep roots grow, because roots only grow deep when the tree is working hard to find water. If you are in a wilderness season, you are not being punished. You are being prepared.

But David's wilderness story deserves to be told in full, because it speaks directly to every soul that has been sent somewhere small, somewhere lonely, somewhere that felt beneath their gifts, and wondered why.

Before David ever faced Goliath, before he was anointed king, before anyone knew his name, he was a shepherd boy. Sent to the fields. Overlooked when Samuel came to anoint a king from his family. His own father Jesse did not even think to call him in from the sheep. And yet it was in those fields, in that forgotten season,

that David developed everything he would need for every battle that followed.

"But David said to Saul, Your servant used to keep sheep for his father. And when there came a lion or a bear and took a lamb from the flock, I went after him and struck him and delivered it out of his mouth. And if he arose against me, I caught him by his beard and struck him and killed him. Your servant has struck down both lions and bears, and this uncircumcised Philistine shall be like one of them, for he has defied the armies of the living God. The Lord who delivered me from the paw of the lion and from the paw of the bear will deliver me from the hand of this Philistine. - 1 Samuel 17:34-37"

David did not learn to kill Goliath in front of a crowd. He learnt it alone, in the wilderness, defending sheep that were not even his own future. The lion and the bear came when no one was watching. No applause. No recognition. Just a boy, a sling, a staff, and a God who was paying attention even when everyone else had looked away.

He killed Goliath with the same sling he used on the lion. The same weapon. The same skill. The same faith. Built in obscurity. Used in history.

What God is building in you in the hidden place is not wasted. The lion is your training.

The more you resist stepping on the coals, the more the coals are heaped on your path. It may come as a surprise that if you want to liberate your soul, you may need to face the lions in the wilderness alone. And God will find a way for you to get through. Not around the fire. Through it. As David went through the fields before the throne, you will go through your wilderness before your destiny.

Know When to Stay, and When to Leave

There is a time to stay, and there is a time to leave. And wisdom is knowing which is which. Staying in a difficult place can be a form of spiritual endurance. If you are growing, if you are learning, if the difficulty is forming something valuable in you. There is deep honour in staying when staying is the right thing, even when it is hard.

But there is also a point when staying in a place of suffering is no longer endurance. When it becomes a diminishment. When the

environment is so toxic, so hostile to your soul's health and growth, that remaining in it is causing you to become less than you were made to be.

At that point, leaving is not weakness. Leaving is wisdom. Leaving is the act of a soul that has decided its own life is worth protecting. You do not owe any job, any relationship, any community, the entirety of your soul.

*"What good is it for a man to gain the whole world, yet
forfeit his soul? - Mark 8:36"*

And here is the grace that so many suffering souls need to hear: leaving is not the end of the lesson. The learning you began in that difficult place goes with you. The strength you developed, the depth you gained, the wisdom you earned through endurance, none of that disappears when you walk out the door.

Leave when you must. Leave without guilt. Leave, if you need to, to gather strength, to find your footing, to breathe fresh air. And then, when you are ready, continue the journey.

From Slave to Master

Clifford S. Waldman describes the soul's progress as a movement from slavery to mastery. Echoing the great biblical narrative of Exodus, in which an entire people are led out of bondage, through the wilderness, and toward the Promised Land. The wilderness is not a detour from the journey. It is the journey.

Good deeds, what Jewish tradition calls mitzvahs, elevate the soul, feeding the Divine Soul and drawing it closer to God's original blueprint for who we are. No fall is permanent. Atonement, the honest reckoning with what we have done and the genuine turning toward something better, cleanses the Earth Soul and restores the connection to the Divine. In Judaism, Yom Kippur. In Christianity, confession and repentance. In Islamic practice, tawbah, turning back to God, is always available, always accepted. The door of return is never closed.

You do not have to be perfect to be on the right path. What matters is the direction of your movement. Are you turning toward the light? Even slowly. Even imperfectly. That is enough.

The sea parted. It always does, for the soul that keeps walking.

A Personal Testimony

This book was born from one of those desperate conversations with God. I was in Johannesburg, working a night shift, sitting on a final written warning which eventually led to my dismissal on the 24th of March 2026, watching people who should have been my colleagues try to block my path before I had even truly started. I have three children depending on me. I had lost my mother ten years before, in 2016. I had moved from city to city, branch to branch, trying to find a place where my gifts would be seen and my dignity respected. And I had not found it.

So I talked to God. Not politely. Not with the careful language of Sunday prayer. I demanded answers. I said: Is this what you have for me? Is this my life? And in that raw, unfiltered conversation, the kind that strips away every performance and leaves just a soul and its Maker, something shifted. Not the circumstances, not immediately. But something in me. A clarity. A direction. The idea that maybe the story of what I had lived through was not just mine to carry privately. Maybe it was mine to give.

This book is my answer to that conversation. If you are reading it in your own long night, in your own Johannesburg, your own final warning, your own season of loss and unrecognised gifts, then this book found you for a reason. You are not alone. The soul knows the

way home. And it will get there. I am still on the road myself. But I am walking. And so are you.

"All poor souls who found their way back here came back for spiritual deepening. Some may leave having never known carnal joy, but rest will surely be theirs in the next world. - The Author"

That is how I know my mother found her rest. And I will soon find mine. If it is not here, then I will find it. May her soul continue to rest.

May your soul find its rest. May your wounds become your wisdom. May your darkness become the very place where light was waiting to be born.

— End —

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Halalisani Ngema was born in Mandeni, on the North Coast of KwaZulu-Natal, South Africa. A place where the soil is deep and the spirit runs deeper. He grew up in a home where faith was not spoken of formally, but was felt in the most sacred of places: in his

grandfather's voice when he prayed, in the reverent tone of a man calling on the ancestors before a ceremony, in the quiet awe of a child who heard the name of God for the first time under an open sky and never forgot it.

His spiritual journey did not follow a straight road. It wound through a roofless rondavel where a cousin first told him God was protection, through a grandmother's living room where an Ethiopian Catholic reverend held Sunday sermons, through the songs of the Shembe Nazareth Baptist Church, the fire of the Apostolic Faith Mission, and eventually into the kind of personal reckoning that only comes when life refuses to cooperate with your best efforts and your most sincere faith.

Halalisani has worked in banking, navigated corporate environments that tested not only his competence but his very sense of self, buried his mother, two siblings and a father, raised three children, and in the midst of all of it, kept talking to God. Sometimes in prayer. Sometimes in frustration. Sometimes in the kind of raw, unfiltered demand for answers that only the truly desperate and the truly faithful dare to bring before the divine.

It was in one of those conversations, sitting with his losses, his questions, and his refusal to stop believing, that this book was born.

Renaissance of the Poor Soul is not a book written from a pulpit. It is a book written from the wilderness. From the crossroads of desperation, frustration, and confusion. From the long night. From the place where a man who has been knocked down more times than he can count still chooses to look up. Halalisani writes not as someone who has arrived, but as someone who is on the road. And who believes, with everything he has, that the road leads somewhere.

He writes this book in memory of his mother, whose soul he is certain has found its rest. And in hope of the rest that awaits every soul willing to stay the journey long enough to find it.

"Fika Nkosi la ngingafikanga khona mina."

Lord, reach beyond the limits of my prayer.

— Mr E Mkhize (Mkhulu Mkhize)

B A C K C O V E R

Nothing is wrong with you.

You have prayed. You have tried. You have done everything you were told to do and still found yourself in the wrong place, overlooked, passed by, standing at doors that would not open. You have begun to wonder, quietly, in the dark, whether the problem is you.

It is not.

Renaissance of the Poor Soul is for every person who has confused a difficult season with a permanent sentence. It is for the soul that has been afflicted, lost, restless, tormented, weary, and still, somehow, refused to stop believing. It is for the person who needs someone to sit with them in the wilderness, not to fix it, but to say: I have been here too. And there is a way through.

This book will not hand you a formula. It will offer you something rarer. The company of honesty. The comfort of being truly understood. And the quiet, stubborn promise that the darkness will not have the last word.

Your renaissance is not behind you. It is ahead.

Renaissance of the Poor Soul

A journey through the many faces of the human spirit

Halalisani Ngema

Renaissance of the Poor Soul

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